

THE INDIAN MS JONES

Three new bumbling Bridgets steer readers through the arena of swinging singletons to make chick lit click



A GIRL NAMED INDIE
by KAVITA DASWANI
Puffin
Price: Rs 200
Pages: 189



SHALL WE DANCE, MR KOSHY?
AN URBAN INDIAN ROMANCE
by THANGASURABI BRIGHT RAJ
Frog Books
Price: Rs 345, Pages: 329



ALMOST SINGLE
by ADVAITA KALA
HarperCollins
Price: Rs 195
Pages: 284

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

They're shopaholic, workaholic and sometimes just plain alcoholic. They love watching their weight, actively chase men and rue the passing of every year. They speak to themselves and sometimes even write post-its to themselves (even if with dodgy spellings). They replace the Chardonnay with Sula, the pub with the local Barista, Barney's with Shopper's Stop and the sari with the little black dress. The granny panties remain.

Indian chick lit is born, where the Bhatia always ends up with the Verma and the Indian girl in America, Opal Mehta-like, is always smarter than the girl named Brooke. Three new bumbling heroines borrowing a bit from Bridget Jones, Carrie Bradshaw and Gossip Girl steer readers through this arena of swinging singletons, as they negotiate parental pressure to marry and peer pressure to have sex. There's Advaita Kala's Aisha Bhatia, who is 29, single, "large-framed", works in a hotel, obsesses about the studly Karan Verma and hates her nagging boss. In Thangasurabi Bright Raj's *Shall We Dance, Mr Koshy?*, Candace Selvakumari Jones is 23, works as a fashion merchandiser, checks into a weight loss programme, obsesses about the tall, dark, handsome Abe E. Koshy and hates her morose boss. In Kavita Daswani's *A Girl Named Indie*, 15-year-old Indira Gandhi in suburban Los

Angeles lusts after a job in Celebrity Style, fantasises about the hippyish Cayman, worries about her jiggly bits and detests her fashionable employer.

The stories may seem all too formulaic, but then how different is Plum Sykes from Sophie Kinsella? Kala's book has liberal doses of humour and sometimes great insight about the most frivolous things, for instance, about shoes: "No matter what weight, height, age or stage of life you are at, your shoe size never changes. Shoes truly emancipate women. They don't care about what you had for dinner last night, or even for the last five years, they still fit." Kala's heroine does kooky things (wraps her friend's ex's

car with toilet roll and waltzes into her boyfriend's boss's room clad in a towel), but all in good cheer. Daswani's Indie, younger than her previous heroines (the Mahim Muslim Tanaya who became a globe-trotting model dating a gay rock star in *Salaam, Paris* and the domesticated Priya who turned Hollywood reporter in *Everything Happens for a Reason*), manages to pick up scoops from desi weddings and Milan washrooms even as she picks up after her boss's two-year-old in a book that is part *Nanny Diaries* and part *Devil Wears Prada*. Daswani, a former fashion journalist, sprinkles tidbits about red carpet gowns and fashion week after-parties. If Kaavyagate hadn't happened, she would have come with her own movie option as well, especially as she comes equipped with crossover smarts (enough mentions of *Om Jagdish Hare* and pressure cookers for the perfect dal).

Bright Raj's booklet is the weakest. She has spirit, like her Orkuting, wannabe writer heroine, but not enough craft. She also doesn't have a publisher who has been able to smoothen her rough edges. Maybe she needs to graduate from chick to woman before writing chick lit worth reading. But by the year-end, these ladies will have some more company: there's the much awaited Meenakshi Reddy Madhavan's *You Are Here* and Anubha Chauhan's *The Zoya Factor*. Part chick lit, part women's fiction, both seem intent on what is clearly an emerging new readership—young women who live Mumbai lives but think Manhattan. With a hint of subversion in its status quo-ist candy-coloured heart. And with enough stilettos slipping on banana peels to keep the laughs coming. ■



SAURABH SINGH